coercing an adversary in a fashion that could induce it to consider resorting to the use of nuclear weapons.[6]

My argument's contribution, however, lies not in this deductive logic, which was pioneered in the work of Thomas Schelling and developed in that of Kenneth Waltz.[7] Instead its principal contribution lies in demonstrating that in this particular case the arguments of nuclear pessimists have been proven to be uniformly wanting. Decision makers in the South Asian region have come to fully grasp the awesome destructive power of nuclear weapons; they have learnt from repeated crises of the inherent dangers of an escalatory spiral and accordingly have taken fitful steps to try and reduce the nuclear danger in the region. Whether similar outcomes would obtain in other regions remains an open question. Leaders in other regions may prove to be more risk-prone; their military organizations may have a greater proclivity for the adoption of offensive doctrines; and their control over their weaponry may prove to be less robust.[8] Careful study of the South Asian case, however, suggests that these dangers are relatively low and so the robustness of nuclear deterrence is not at question.

SOUTH ASIA'S LONG PEACE

An important debate exists about the causes of the "long peace" that characterized Cold War Europe. The mutual possession of nuclear weapons and the horrific consequences of their possible use, according to one school of thought, can explain the long peace.[9] The other school contends that the explanation must be sought elsewhere. Its proponents believe that the terrifying memories of the two world wars effectively inoculated the population of the region to recoil from the prospect of a major war.[10]

The memories of war do not play a significant role in shaping the strategic behavior of political elites or mass publics in South Asia. All the Indo-Pakistani wars involved considerable mutual military restraint and produced relatively low levels of casualties.[11] However, in the South Asian context, the memories of the partition of the British Indian empire in 1947 have profoundly shaped the views of